who but Bairam should happen to be cruising on the river, just then! Unerring as fate, the elephant made for the regent's boat – only this time, thank God, its mahout managed to control the animal before it could do any harm. Akbar sent the keeper, in chains, to Bairam: a generous gesture that should have inspired an equally magnanimous forgiveness. Instead, the regent had this mahout killed, too.

As he had done after the first debacle with his elephants in Mankot, Akbar said nothing. Instead, he went 'travelling and hunting', writes Abul Fazl, or 'worshipped the incomparable Deity'. This time, however, Akbar was four years older.

How much a person changes from fourteen to eighteen. Akbar's voice would have broken. He would have experienced that sudden spurt that stretches a boy like bamboo in rain. He would be stronger, more skilled with sword and musket; the boy who put grown men in leashes at nine would be even more adept at exercising authority. Meanwhile, it is an unfortunate truth that the allure of power begets impatience; princes are not known to await their turn at the throne with equanimity. How much more frustrating it must have been, then, to occupy the throne but 'not [have] absolute power in his own kingdom'?[83]

It was Bairam who exercised authority on Akbar's behalf, Bairam who controlled the treasury, and Bairam, most crucially, who promoted his own favourites and persecuted his own enemies. Back in Kabul, a decade ago, ambitious chiefs had gathered around Akbar because the child was heir to Humayun. How long would it be before men and women in Delhi, whose ambitions were being thwarted by Bairam, made their own claims on Akbar, now that he was king?

'[E]nvious, malignant men' came to him, whispering complaints, writes Nizamuddin. To ask whether it was Akbar's own annoyance or the influence of Bairam's enemies that finally tipped the scales against the regent is like asking about the chicken and the egg. Whatever the whispers in his ear, Akbar had grievances of his own to match them. Bairam was not the kindly sort of guardian Munim had been, allowing Akbar to skip school and fly pigeons. Instead, Bairam had confiscated Akbar's elephants, killed Akbar's mahouts, and didn't even allow the padishah a privy purse.[84] So, writes Abul Fazl, it was Akbar who revealed Bairam's 'evil intentions'